Archiving qualitative datasets

Annika Valaranta, Finnish Social Science Data Archive (FSD)

10.10.2019 All eyes on data –workshop

Turku University

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Workshop timetable

- 13.15-14:15 Archived data types & data management
- 14:15-14:30 Break
- 14:30-15:30 Anonymisation workshop
- 15:30-15:45 Discussion

Archived qualitative data types

FSD: YES: data in digital form: transcribed interviews, writings, pictures, chat discussions, news article collections, observing diaries or notes

- articles and pictures in newspapers/magazines, illustrations, comics (agreement between FSD and Kopiosto Copyright Society)

- NO: social media data, paper data, audio or video material
- Other archives: CSC: Ida, The Language Bank of Finland (Kielipankki), The National Archives of Finland (Kansallisarkisto), UTU: Archives of History, Culture and Arts Studies, Folklive archives (Kansanperinteen arkisto), Zenodo

When is archiving possible (to FSD)?

- Informing participants meets the legal requirements of GDPR (General Data Protection Regulation) and ethical requirements
- Archiving is mentioned in the information sheet, mention of FSD/Tietoarkisto!
- Clear relation of responsibilities
- Data is understandable
- Sufficient information on data collection

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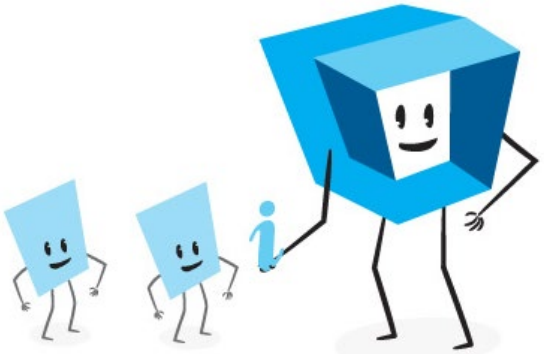

INFORMING PARTICIPANTS

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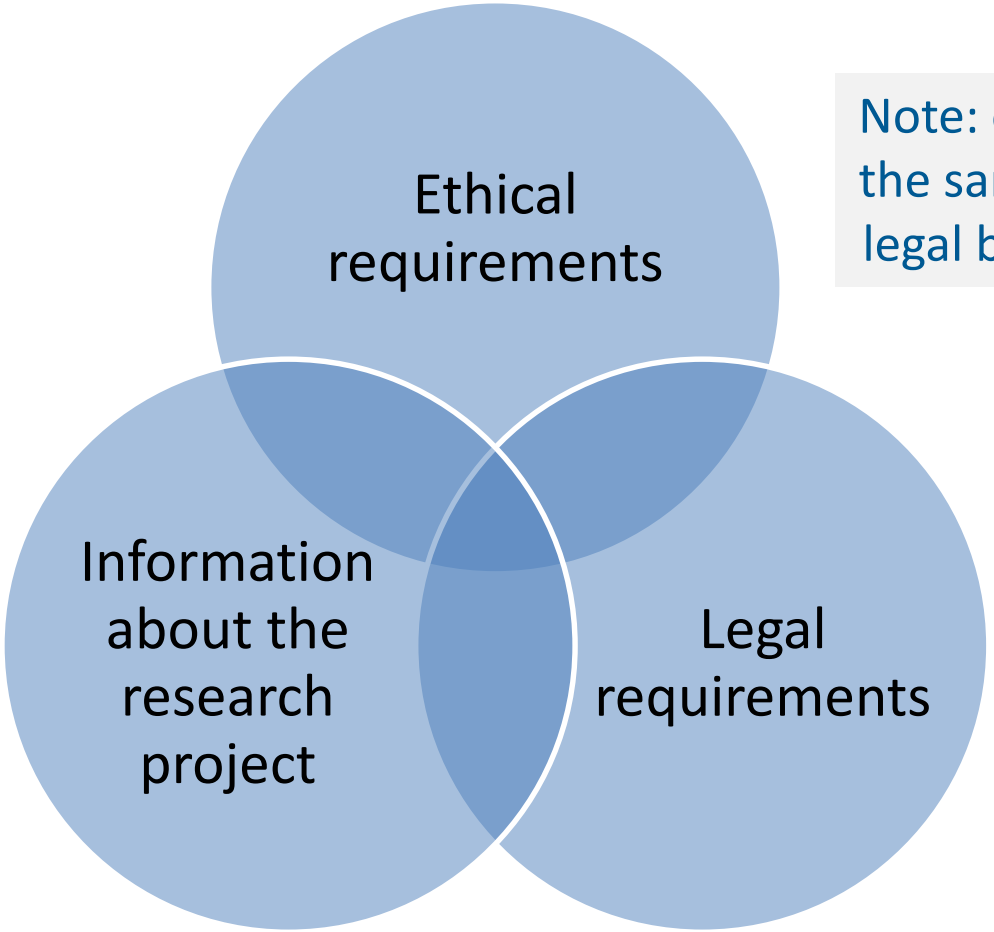
Information types

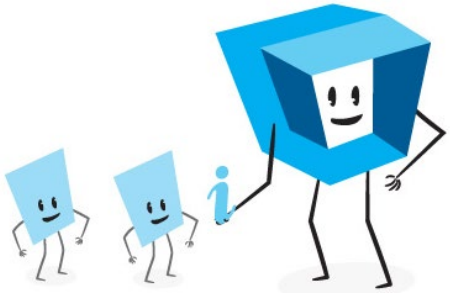


Note: ethical consent is not the same than consent as a legal basis of personal data

Provision of information to the participants general principles from GDPR

Research participants have the right to get all the information about the personal data processing (GDPR).

- Concise (tiivis)
- Transparent (läpinäkyvä)
- Intelligible (helposti ymmärrettävä)
- Easily accessible (helposti saatavilla)
- Using clear and plain language (selkeä ja yksinkertainen kieli)



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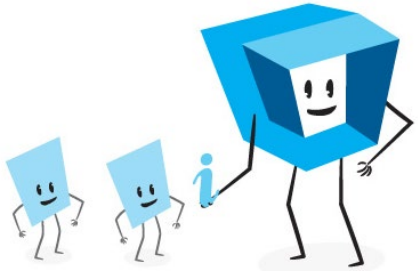
Provision of information: layered approach

Information is given usually layered in two parts:

1. **Research information sheet** that includes the most important information
   a) purpose(s) for which personal data are processed, i.e. research
   b) identity of the data controller
   c) rights of research participants
   d) (unexpected impacts of personal data processing)
2. **Detailed privacy notice** (tietosuojailmoitus) includes more detailed information considering the data use (may be separated document or link to the webside)



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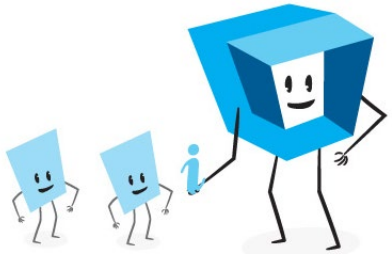
Ethical rights of participant



People participating in research have the right

1. to participate voluntarily but also to refuse to participate
2. to discontinue their participation at any time without suffering any negative consequences
3. to withdraw their consent to participation in the research at any time
4. **to receive information on** the content of the research, **the processing of personal data** and how the research will be conducted in practice

Mention rights 1-3 when informing participants + rights from legal basis!

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Provision privacy legislation information

Data obtained from the participant

Data obtained from a source other than the research participant

Has an effect on which information should be given to the participant

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Legal basis of processing data (art. 6)

In scientific research, basis for the processing is usually one of the following:

- processing is necessary for the performance of a task carried out in the public interest (art. 6 e)
- the data subject has given consent to the processing of his or her personal data for one or more specific purposes
- Other cases: controllers obligations, protect data subjects vital interests etc.
- For eg. writings: National privacy law: For processing carried out for journalistic purposes or the purpose of academic artistic or literary expression

How can I know which approach to use? Contact data protection officer

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Processing of special categories of personal data (art. 9)

If data treats special categories, there must be a lawful right to handle them. In the research the justifications are:

- processing is necessary for archiving purposes in the public interest, scientific or historical research purposes or statistical purposes
- explicit consent from the data subject
- Also others: e.g. personal data which are manifestly made public by the data subject

NOTE: Do also data protection impact assessment (DPIA)

Special categories by GDPR:

racial or ethnic origin, political opinions, religious or philosophical beliefs, or trade union membership, the processing of genetic data, biometric data for the purpose of uniquely identifying a natural person, health data, a natural person's sex life or sexual orientation

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DPIA and ethical review

DPIA: Data Protection Impact Assessment (Vaikutusten arviointi):

- research where personal data are processed on a large scale
- personal data includes matching or combining datasets
- personal data of vulnerable individuals are processed
- personal data are processed in the innovative use or application of new technology

Ethical review from human sciences ethics committee

- Participant has not sufficient information about the research
- Intervening the physical integrity of the participant
- Researching on minors under the age 15 without separate consent from the parents
- Research that exposes exceptionally strong stimuli
- Research has risk to cause mental harm
- Research could involve a threat to safety

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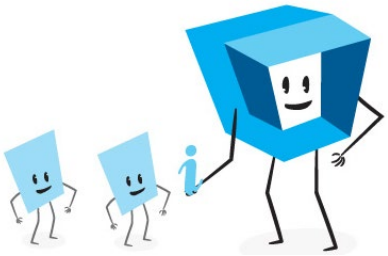
Consent for achiving qualitative dataset example



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Consent for archiving interview/text at Finnish Social Science Data Archive

☐ I consent to the archiving of my interview/text at the Finnish Social Science Data Archive for reuse in research, studying and teaching (or reuse in research or scientific theses and dissertations starting from Master's theses).

☐ I do not consent to the archiving of my interview/text at the Finnish Social Science Data Archive.

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TIPS FOR PROCESSING THE DATA

Transcription and naming of data files

Transcription:

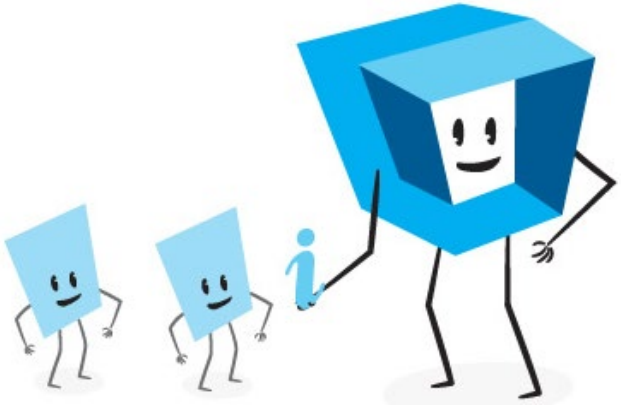
- Speaker demarcation should be consistent throughout the transcription
- Each time the person speaking changes, his or her speech should be transcribed as a discrete unit, always starting from a new row. F.ex.

I: What do you think about dogs?

P: They make me so happy

I: Why they make you so happy?

Systematic and consistent naming of data files



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Enter background information into data files

For textual data, background data are systematically entered in the beginning of each data unit (e.g. interview transcript)

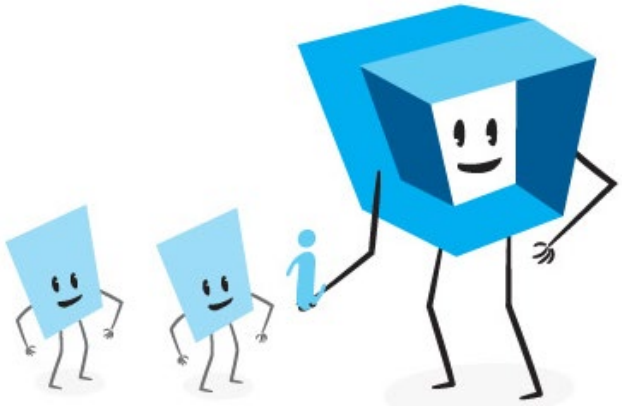
Interview date: 08.02.2013 [=8 February 2013]

Interviewer: Matt Miller

Occupation of interviewee: Journalist

Age of interviewee: 32

Gender of interviewee: Male



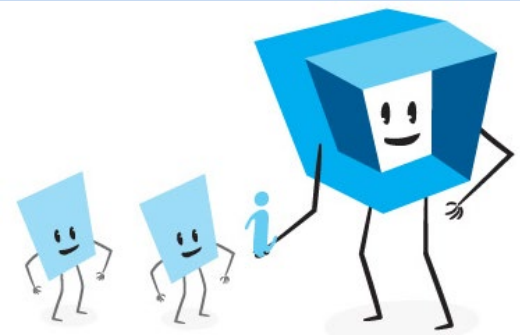
Sufficient metadata available for reuse:

What information is needed to understand the data when reusing it? Try to think about it from the viewpoint of a new user who does not know anything about the data.

Essentials: original purpose, authors, population, unit of observation, sampling of the data units, data collection dates, contextual information

Examples of relevant material:

- interview guidelines, possible stimulus material, writing invitation, transcription guidelines etc.
- information sheet
- information about the research project



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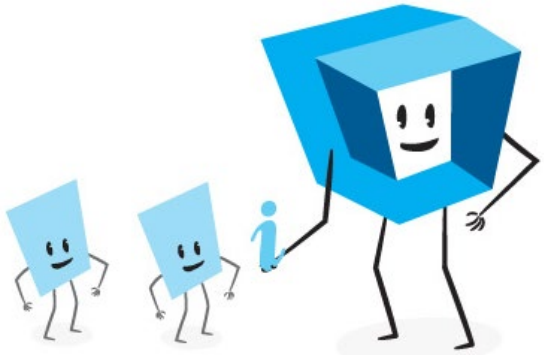
ABC of Anonymisation - Workshop

Before collection the data: minimise the amount of personal data

- Which background information is needed about research subjects (use structured and standardized forms if possible)
- Avoid asking specifying or sensitive questions that will very likely produce responses requiring heavy anonymisation measures

NO: "*Could you tell us which workplaces your father and mother have worked in during their lives...*"



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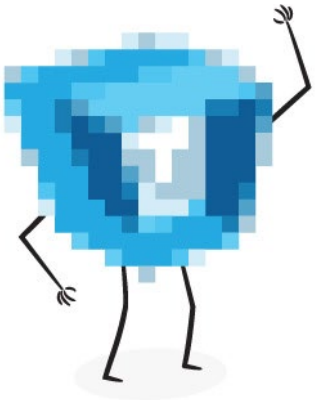
Consepts



- Personal data

any information relating to an identified or identifiable natural person

- Anonymous data

An individual data unit (person) cannot be re-identified with reasonable effort based on the data or by combining it with other sources

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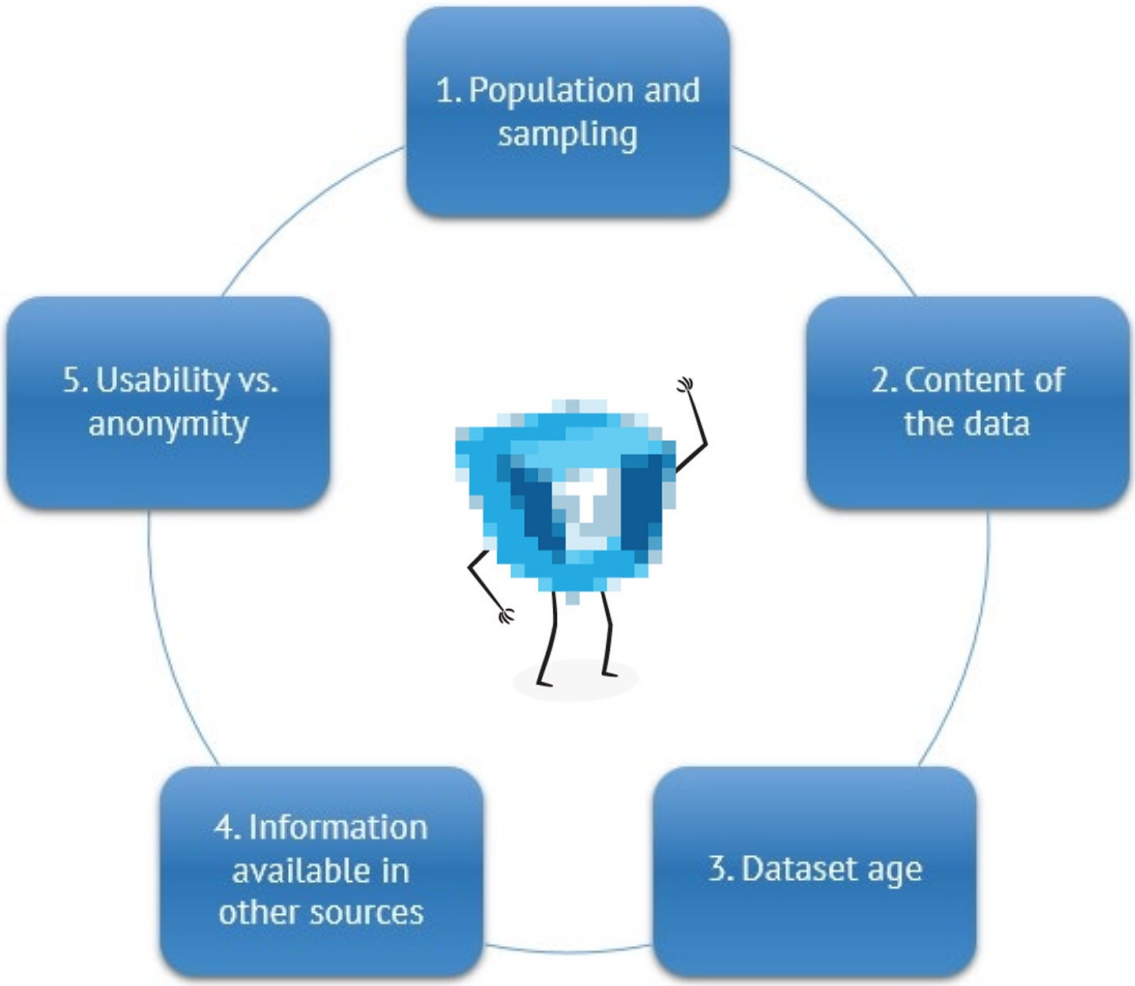
Anonymisation planning



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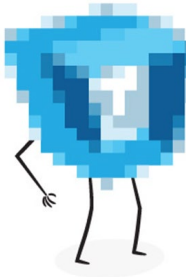
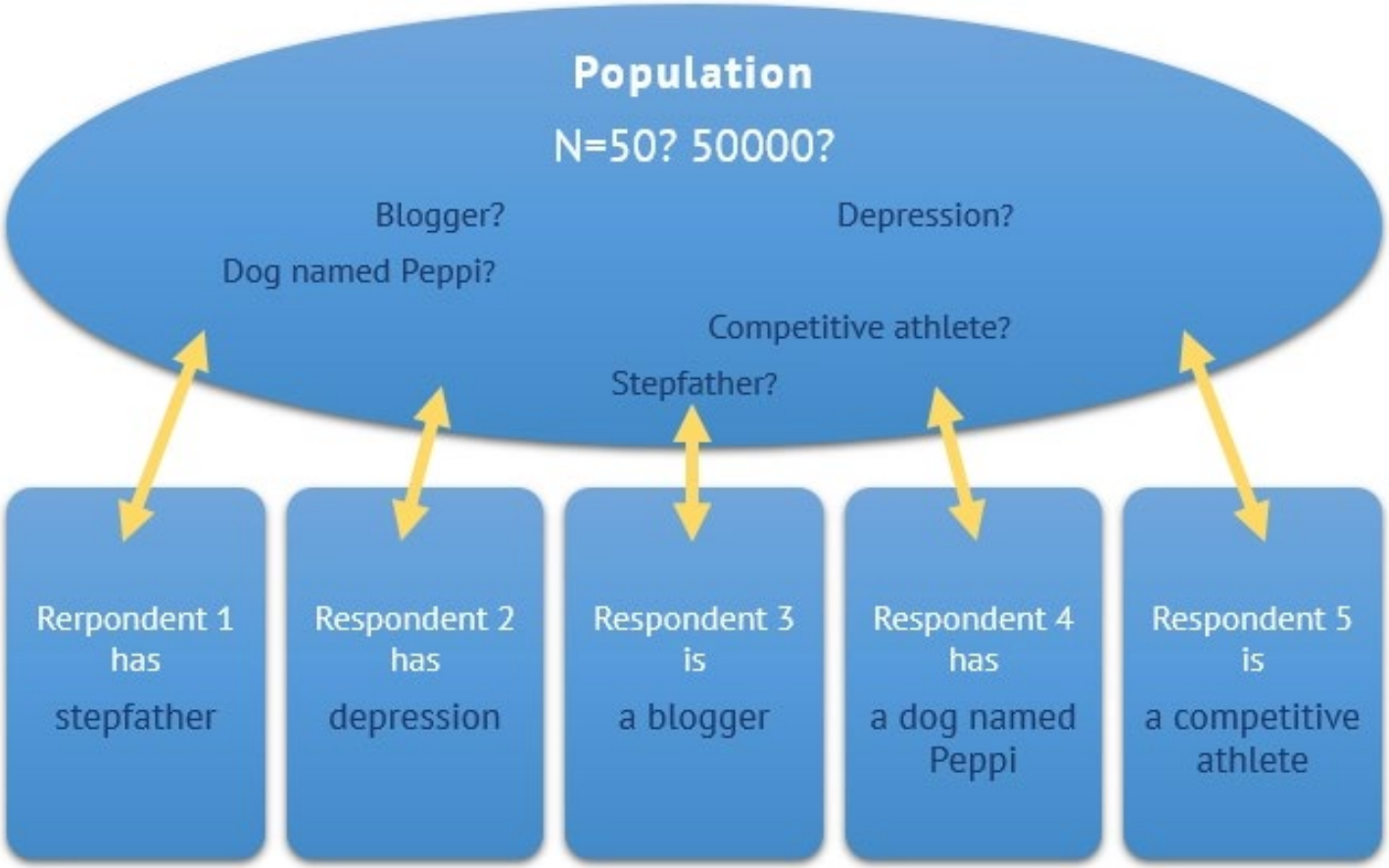
What is exceptional or unique information? Do we always need to remove it?





ASK: Is the information exceptional among target population? If yes, ask whether it is available from some source. If yes, the information need to be anonymised. If not, information can be remained.

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Anonymisation techniques

Direct identifiers are always removed in anonymisation

Replacing personal names with aliases: Cathy → [Sarah].

Generalising techniques:

- coarsening e.g. [town in Western Finland], [company in the metal industry], [elementary school], [shopping centre]
- categorising (e.g. age into groups of 5 years). Try to leave the categories as detailed as possible, e.g. do not categorise ages into groups of 10 years if not necessary.
- deleting: information/variables/participants

Randomising techniques:

- e.g. modifying age +-2 years, changing the date of an event, or swapping values between respondents. Use with caution!

Make sure that the removed information cannot be deduced!

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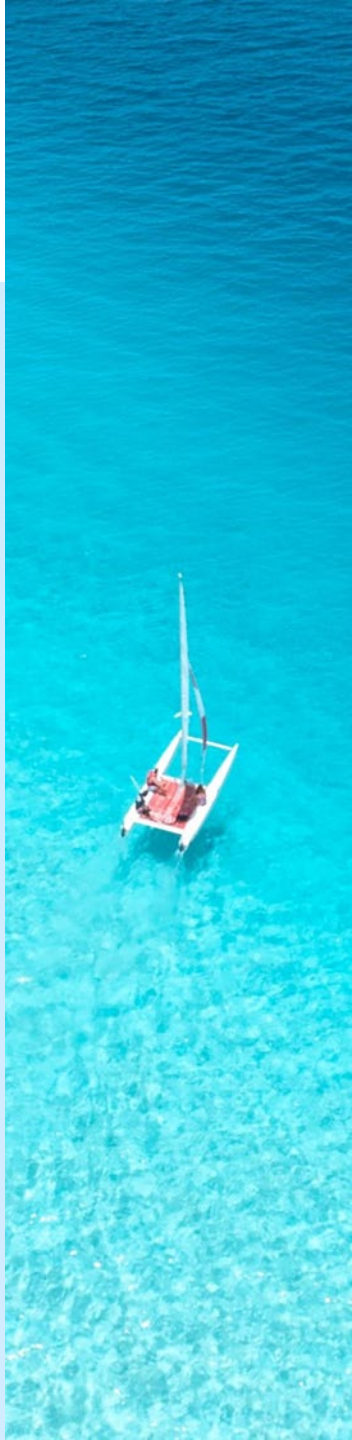
Practical anonymisation tips for qualitative data:

1. Plan anonymisation before processing to ensure consistent anonymisation. Experiment with anonymisation by processing a couple of files at first. Document the main strategies for anonymisation. Note that anonymisation cannot be planned thoroughly before the data are transcribed, but it is possible to remove direct identifiers and names, for example, already during transcription.
2. Always copy your files and anonymise the copies. This way, any errors in anonymisation can still be fixed and checked from the original files.
3. Create a work document that includes, for instance, aliases used for personal names as well as categorisations that require consistency. Example: Interview 1: Simon=Matthew, Helsinki=[city 1].
4. Use specific characters, such as [square brackets], for anonymisation to help keep track of what has been changed and what has not. Do not use text styling, such as *cursive* or coloured text, because these changes may disappear.
5. Utilise 'find & replace' e.g. on Word to change names to their aliases. Be careful with the 'replace all' command, since the letters can appear as part of other words (e.g. Tim – estimate).
6. When anonymisation is finished, erase original files and lists of aliases.



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Anonymisation planning: you may ask..

1. Who were the target population of the study? What is known about the population beforehand?
2. Content of the data:
   a) What kinds of direct and indirect identifiers do the data contain? What combinations of information in the data could be used to identify a person?
   b) Does the dataset contain information relating to third persons and can they be identified based on the information in the dataset?
   c) Do the data contain exceptional or unique observations?
   d) Is the information in the data sensitive?
3. What information on respondents are available in other sources?
4. **Usability vs. anonymity**: what information to keep and what to "sacrify"?

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